Newsletter - December 2020

500 Women Scientists Bern-Fribourg

Despite all the odds, this year implied a positive turning point for our pod. We started 2020 small and we move into 2021 with more than 50 members, of which 16 are part of our core team. We inaugurated both outreach and networking events and obtained funding to support them through the Equality Office and the Promotion Fund from the University of Bern. This year we also started a range of projects, such as campaigning to make science a better place for women, work that will hopefully come to fruition next year.

On 11th February 2020, we launched the first ***500 Women Scientists in the Pub*** at ONO Bern, a science outreach event aimed to increase the visibility of women scientists as experts in their field. We had two inspiring talks from Dr Adria LeBeouf and Dr Teresa Chávez-Capilla, who succeeded in engaging a very motivated audience. This positive experience made us repeat in September, when we enjoyed the captivating talks from Dr Ana Benítez-Mateos and Dr Claudia Kasper. Combining science and games, these events create an excellent environment for learning, socializing and having fun. Although our next event will have to be online, we are working on making it as engaging as in person. Stay tuned for updates!



This year has also seen the start of our ***Networking lunches***, a series of monthly networking events to meet women leaders in academia, industry, funding bodies and research institutions. We counted with the presence of Laura Lots (SNSF), who told us all about AcademiaNet; Dr Emma Hodcroft (UniBas), with who we discussed the research and public communication on COVID-19; and Prof Irene Adrian-Kalchhauser (VetSuisse), who gave us inspiring advice on the transition from postdoc to professor. We are looking forward to continuing with our networking events in spring next year so keep on the loop for more details!







Our **blog** has been extremely active this year. Combining personal opinion articles and female scientists' profiles, it counts already with a few interesting reads to enjoy during the break. ***Paths Through Science*** presents to us the professional trajectory of excellent researchers who had to overcome different challenges to keep up with their passion. If you have an interesting story you want to share in our blog, you can contact Gabrielle Vance for an interview here. If what you want is to share your opinion on a relevant topic for the scientific community, you can do so by contacting Vandana S. Kushwaha here.

All these achievements would not have been possible without the effort of our core team, to which we want to say a big **THANK YOU!**

500 Women Scientists Bern-Fribourg Pod Coordinators
Claudia Kasper and Teresa Chávez-Capilla

TOP STORIES

The grey zones of sexual harassment

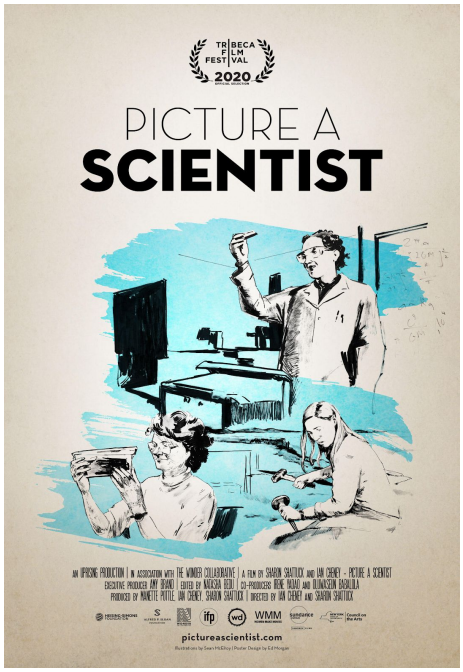
Many women have been confronted with awkward social situations at least once in their lives



in which they felt very uncomfortable, but struggled to call inappropriate. Those so-called grey zones appear to be open to interpretation, and the victim is often not sure whether she is overly sensitive ('He certainly did not mean it THAT way.' - 'Feeling uncomfortable in this encounter is MY fault, not his.'). This guide, "It's not that grey. How to identify the grey area — a practical guide for the twilight zone of sexual harassment" by Sara Hassan and Juliette Sanchez-Lambert helps to see a little more clearly and enables affected women to better categorize what has happened. The goal of this guide is to show that it is very important to realize that incidents of sexual harassment are not unique or isolated, but follow certain patterns, and that you don't have to put up with them. Reading the guide really helps to listen and believe your inner voice - "When you feel that something is odd – well, it most likely is." Finally, tips for bystanders and on reporting incidents of sexual harassment are offered. The guide can be downloaded from here and you can also see the cartoons of *Did this really happen?* here to understand how common this behaviour is and which situations other women have already experienced.

How do you picture that scientist?

We are all biased when we imagine scientists: often as a white old man in a lab coat doing crazy complicated calculations or performing extravagant experiments with smoky colored mixtures. Still, we all know that is not true, but we struggle to change our minds. In June 2020, the release of ***Picture a Scientist*** intended to break that image by sharing the stories of the biologist Nancy Hopkins, the chemist Raychelle Burks and the geologist Jane Willenbring. The film goes through the different challenges these three women had to overcome to be where they are right now; including the battles they had to pick to improve the career options of future female scientists. This documentary does not leave you untouched. In fact, if you are a woman in academia you will see yourself reflected in many of the situations Nancy, Raychelle and Jane experienced. Watching this film is a must, not just for scientists, but also for the general public



as it brings awareness to many unspoken and urgent topics that affect the collective vision of women in science. We need to start that uncomfortable conversation, speak about the unspoken and motivate change. If you have not watched ***Picture a Scientist*** yet, you can register here for the screening Better Science is organizing in January next year.

...And by the way, thanks for undermining female researchers

On November 17, 2020, Nature Communications published a paper entitled "The association between early career informal mentorship in academic collaborations and junior author performance", which has been retracted on 21st December 2020. In the paper, the authors presented the analysis of a large data set on co-authorship in the light of mentoring relationships and their association with the mentees' (as well as mentors') further careers. They concluded that having female mentors does not benefit female mentees, nor do these relationships benefit the female mentors' careers. This article has received severe criticism not only for its bleak conclusion that is downright damaging to business for female PIs, but also for the methodology used and the interpretation of the data (see here and here). The main criticisms are the conflation of mentorship and co-authorship, the definition of success as merely citation rate, the rather uncurated massive dataset that spans many decades in which the participation of women in science has changed dramatically, the practice of inferring gender from given names and the complete disregard of social science. Finally, the failure to provide alternative explanations, or any explanations at all, as to why the patterns found occur in the first place, such as through bias in acceptance of articles or citation by female authors, is striking. In the discussion, two (weak) explanations are provided but they have no bearing on the policy advice, which is mainly to discourage same-gender mentoring relationships.

Casually speaking, the authors rediscover the truism that protégés of big shots seem to develop into big shots themselves. Coincidentally, big shots are still predominantly men... This paper is harmful for women in science because it advises policy makers to discourage same-gender mentoring relationships based on sloppy analyses that completely disregard the societal context of their findings. In a science culture where articles with female authors articles receive harsher peer reviews and are less likely to be accepted (see for instance here), this seems a grotesquely misguided recommendation that is likely to further complicate women's careers in science. A letter expressing "Affirmation of support for female scientists and scholars'' has currently almost 7,400 signatories and can still be signed.

DON´T MISS

Our last interview in Paths through Science

DON´T FORGET TO SIGN

The petition against precariousness in Swiss higher education

CHECK OUT

The Better Science initiative from the University of Bern

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